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Writing an Effective Professional Goal

Well-defined goals provide a meaningful sense of direction and purpose, which can keep you motivated when challenges arise. Clearly articulated goals can help you to think strategically about the steps needed to achieve them and allows for regular and purposeful evaluation and reflection.

Therefore, when crafting your professional goal, it's important to remember that you:

Do

- Focus your goal(s) on your own professional growth, relative to your career and aspirations
- Ensure that your goal is in relation to what you will learn, and should be focused on the learning you plan to undertake.

Don't

- Focus primarily on numerical student outcomes, rather than your personal learning/ training or development
- Make your goal too wide to be measurable e.g. " To develop teaching in the school"
- Make your goal too focused on narrow data-driven outcomes : " The progress score of my school will be X..."
- Create goals that are too removed from your everyday practice
- Create goals that are not aligned to values, goals or strategic aims of your school or the wider Trust
- Create goals that are irrelevant to your role or professional journey or irrelevant to current educational thinking
- Make your goal a 'to-do' list of things you will undertake

Structuring your goal (Teachers MPS and UPS)

You may find this goal generator helpful in supporting you to structure your goal effectively.

To...	Skills/ knowledge/ understand/ ability...	So that...	I will achieve this by/ through...
Improve...	My understanding of...	My students/ my department/ my Year 8 class/ my curriculum/ my teaching/ my classroom practice...	[List the actions you will undertake in order to achieve this goal, e.g. attending professional learning on _____, shadowing, observing, collaborating with etc]
Enhance...	My practice in relation to...		
Develop my expertise in...			
Research a series of strategies to...	Build my knowledge of...		
Practise...	My skills of...		
Explore...	Research relating to... To enhance my understanding of...		
Build a wider awareness of...			

Exemplar Goals

Here are a series of example goals to support you in devising an effective goal. These examples are successful because they:

1. Clearly articulate what the teacher plans to learn
2. Are specific in terms of their focus
3. Their success can be measured through a range of means
4. Clearly identify a group of students who will benefit from the teacher's new learning

"To improve my knowledge and skills in effective scaffolding so that lessons are more accessible to students with SEND".

"To develop my expertise in retrieval practice, so that students in Year 7 can retain, recall and apply their prior learning more successfully"

"To research and implement interactive digital teaching methods and technology to make science lessons more engaging at Key Stage 3"

Non-Examples

The following table gives examples of poor professional goals and the reasons they would not be suitable.

Non-example	Justification
Write a new scheme of learning with new tasks on entry	This goal focuses primarily on the 'task' the teacher will undertake rather than the learning that they will undertake in order to improve the quality of the start of lessons. What sort of research/ learning will the teacher undertake in order to improve the quality and rigour of the start of lessons?
Enhance the Year 11 scheme of learning so that pupils at KS4 gain 90% 7+	The drawbacks on measuring impact of teacher learning solely on external examinations is clearly articulated below: "Measuring impact in terms of pupils' outcomes in external exams is tempting because it is very visible and gives us numbers that appear easy to compare year on year. However, if we are not careful, we end up valuing only that which we can measure, and so being none the wiser as to what the best bets are for our school and what is or is not genuinely working well. Discussions around impact should focus on a variety of outcomes so that we can seek to triangulate information and work out what is leading us in a positive direction." (Enser, Mark; Enser, Zoe. The CPD Curriculum: Creating conditions for growth (p. 114). Crown House Publishing).
Develop a booklet for Year 9 students with SEND in DT	This goal is too focused on the outcome, rather than the learning that the teacher will undertake in order to improve provision for students with SEND in DT.
To add meta-cognition to my teaching	This goal is too wide to be actionable. If set, it could lead to quite vague and unfocused learning for the teacher. There is no focus on a variety of outcomes that could come from this teacher's new learning.
Create a homework assignment for Year 10 students with spellings and literacy challenges	This goal is too focused on an outcome, rather than any learning or development that the teacher would undertake. 'Doing more' literacy and spellings won't improve literacy or spelling- what new learning does this teacher need to support the most effective implementation?

Structuring your goal (TLR Holders)

You may find this goal generator helpful in supporting you to structure your goal effectively.

To...	Skills/ knowledge/ understand/ ability...	So that...	I will achieve this by/ through...
Improve...	My understanding of...	My department/ my pastoral team/ my form tutors/ colleagues	[List the actions you will undertake in order to achieve this goal, e.g. attending professional learning on _____, shadowing, observing, collaborating with etc]
Enhance...	My practice in relation to...		
Develop my expertise in...			
Research a series of strategies to...	Build my knowledge of...		
Practise...	My skills of...		
Explore...	Research relating to... To enhance my understanding of...		
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Exemplar Goals

Here are a series of example goals to support you in devising an effective goal. These examples are successful because they:

1. Clearly articulate what the leader plans to learn
2. Are specific in terms of their focus
3. Their success can be measured through a range of means
4. Clearly identify a group of students/staff who will benefit from the leader's new learning

"To enhance my leadership of collaborative planning processes in my department, so that curriculum delivery is more coherent and aligned with the school and Trust's vision for excellence. "

"To develop my expertise in supporting colleagues with classroom management strategies so that behaviour for learning improves across my department, particularly in Year 9. "

" To research and implement strategies for developing students' critical thinking skills in my subject area so that they are better prepared for higher-level questioning and analysis in Key Stage 4.

Non-Examples

The following table gives examples of poor professional goals and the reasons they would not be suitable.

Non-example	Justification
"Improve teaching in the department through meta-cognition"	"Improve teaching" is too broad and lacks clarity. It doesn't define what aspects of teaching need improvement (e.g., pedagogy, assessment, student engagement) or how success could be measured. There is no sense of what the TLR holder themselves will learn and how their learning will impact the teachers and pupils in their department.
"Make lessons in the department more engaging"	The term "engaging" is subjective and can mean different things to different people. There's no clear standard for what constitutes an "engaging" lesson. There is no sense of what the TLR holder themselves will learn as part of this process and how students might benefit clearly from this learning.
"Become a better leader by doing an NPQ."	"Become a better leader" doesn't define what leadership qualities need development (e.g., communication, decision-making, implementation). Completing an NPQ does not guarantee better leadership- which skills, attributes or new learning will be applied and which stakeholders will benefit?
"To work with the department to re-write the department marking and feedback policy"	This goal is too focused on an outcome, rather than any learning or development that the TLR holder or the wider team would undertake.
"To increase the number of girls engaging in extracurricular activities"	This goal is too focused on an outcome, rather than any learning or development that the TLR holder or the wider team would undertake, likewise it is currently too wide to be actionable.

Structuring your goal (Assistant Headteachers/ Deputy Headteachers)

You may find this goal generator helpful in supporting you to structure your goal effectively.

To...	Skills/ knowledge/ understand/ ability...	So that...	I will achieve this by/through...
Improve...	My understanding of...	My team/ our curriculum/ our teaching/ departments/ middle leaders...	[List the actions you will undertake in order to achieve this goal, e.g. attending professional learning on _____, shadowing, observing, collaborating with etc]
Enhance...	My practice in relation to...		
Develop my expertise in...			
Research a series of strategies to...	Build my knowledge of...		
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Exemplar Goals

Here are a series of example goals to support you in devising an effective goal. These examples are successful because they:

1. Clearly articulate what the leader plans to learn
2. Are specific in terms of their focus for development
3. Their success can be measured through a range of means
4. Clearly identify a group of students/ staff who will benefit from the leader's new learning

"To enhance my understanding of effective strategies to reduce the disadvantaged gap, so that I can lead initiatives that significantly improve outcomes for disadvantaged students in Year 9."

"To enhance my expertise in leading research-informed whole-school attendance strategies, so that I can effectively increase attendance, with a particular focus on persistent absentees in Years 7-10. "

" To build a wider awareness of effective strategies for improving assessment systems at Key Stage 3, so that I can support middle leaders in creating more impactful and meaningful assessments that drive student progress."

Non-Examples

The following table gives examples of poor professional goals and the reasons they would not be suitable.

Non-example	Justification
Revise the curriculum at Key Stage Three	The goal doesn't specify what aspects of the curriculum need revision (content, sequencing, depth, etc.) or why these changes are necessary. Secondly, it doesn't make clear what the intended outcome of the curriculum revision is—whether it's to improve student engagement, close learning gaps, or align better with assessments. The goal lacks specificity. The scale of the revisions and the timelines are unclear. Is this a one-year overhaul or an incremental improvement? Is it for one subject or the entire Key Stage? What is the need for the change?
Ensure All SEND Students Achieve Expected Progress	This goal assumes that all SEND students can achieve the same progress without recognising their varied needs and individual starting points. The goal doesn't outline any strategies for how to support SEND students effectively or mention staff training or resource allocation. The goal should focus on progress relative to individual needs and targets, rather than blanket expectations that don't account for diverse learning profiles.
Reduce the Pupil Premium Gap	Whilst closing the gap between Pupil Premium and non-Pupil Premium students is vital, the goal doesn't specify any strategies, interventions, or specific focus areas. The goal is not specific about how much the gap should be reduced, or by when. It also fails to outline how progress will be monitored and who, exactly, is set to benefit. Reducing the gap should be tied to improving outcomes in specific areas (e.g., literacy, numeracy, attendance) rather than being treated as a standalone goal.

Structuring your goal (Trust Directors)

You may find this goal generator helpful in supporting you to structure your goal effectively.

To...	Skills/ knowledge/ understand/ ability...	So that...	I will achieve this by/through...
Improve...	My understanding of...	My team/ our curriculum/ our teaching/ departments/ middle leaders...	[List the actions you will undertake in order to achieve this goal, e.g. attending professional learning on _____, shadowing, observing, collaborating with etc]
Enhance...	My practice in relation to...		
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 4. Clearly identify a group of students/ staff who will benefit from the leader's new learning
- "To build my understanding of innovative digital transformation strategies so that I can effectively lead the Trust's implementation of cutting-edge technologies in teaching, learning, and leadership practices."

"To develop my expertise in talent management and staff retention strategies so that the Trust becomes an employer of choice, improving staff well-being, satisfaction, and retention rates."

"To research and implement innovative leadership development programs for middle and senior leaders so that we can create a sustainable leadership pipeline across the Trust, supporting long-term growth and development."

Non-Examples

The following table gives examples of poor professional goals and the reasons they would not be suitable.

Non-example	Justification
Improve leadership skills when supporting schools through school improvement work	This goal is overly broad and lacks specificity. "Leadership skills" can encompass many different areas—communication, decision-making, team management, etc.—without clarity on which aspect of leadership is the focus. Additionally, it lacks measurable criteria, making it difficult to determine progress or success. Without a defined outcome, this goal fails to drive intentional improvement or development.
Increase student outcomes by 5% this year in two schools in the Trust	While this goal has a measurable outcome, it fails to account for the complex factors influencing student outcomes. Trust Directors have an indirect role in student performance, and focusing on a specific percentage improvement risks creating undue pressure without addressing the systems, structures, or strategies needed to support this improvement. It's a goal that relies too heavily on a metric that may be beyond the direct control of the leader and is too wide to be accurately measurable.
Ensure that all schools in the Trust are compliant with safeguarding requirements.	This goal is important but poorly framed. Ensuring compliance is a baseline responsibility, not a stretch goal for growth. It doesn't push the Director toward leadership development or innovation and does not account for any learning that may be undertaken by the Director to support individual growth. Additionally, safeguarding is an ongoing process that requires more than just compliance; fostering a culture of safety and proactively addressing risks would be a more strategic and growth-oriented goal.

Structuring your goal (Headteachers)

You may find this goal generator helpful in supporting you to structure your goal effectively.

To...	Skills/ knowledge/ understand/ ability...	So that...	I will achieve this by/through...
Improve...	My understanding of...	my senior team/ our school/our teaching/ departments...	[List the actions you will undertake in order to achieve this goal, e.g. attending professional learning on _____, shadowing, observing, collaborating with etc]
Enhance...	My practice in relation to...		
Develop my expertise in...			
Research a series of strategies to...	Build my knowledge of...		
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"To research and develop my thinking on financial sustainability models so that our school can sustain a broad and financially viable curriculum model at Key Stage 5" can better identify underperforming areas, particularly in relation to disadvantaged and SEND students, and implement targeted interventions to close the attainment gap".

"To enhance my understanding of leadership for social mobility so that I can lead initiatives that reduce inequality within the school, ensuring that all students, regardless of background, have equal opportunities to succeed. "

Non-Examples

The following table gives examples of poor professional goals and the reasons they would not be suitable.

Non-example	Justification
Increase student attendance, especially at Key Stage 3	This goal is vague and lacks specificity. It does not define what "increase" means (e.g., by how much?), nor does it provide a timeline for achieving the goal. Additionally, it doesn't include strategies or metrics for measuring progress, making it difficult to assess success. This goal does not put professional learning at the centre of its focus and is too broad to be measurable.
To increase assessment scores across the school so that Year 9 students make beyond the expected levels of progress.	This goal is ambiguous and does not specify which subjects or grades are being targeted, or what new thinking/ learning will be used to benefit the wider school. Additionally, it does not outline how improvement will be measured or what "better" means (e.g., a percentage increase) or the sorts of actions that need to be undertaken in order. Without clear criteria focus and direction, this goal will not be achievable or impactful.
To develop a framework for leadership development across the school	This goal too broad to be actionable and lacks clarity and focus. It does not specify which leadership skills need improvement (e.g., communication, decision-making, etc.) or what sort of new learning or development will be undertaken to support the school's development.

Structuring your goal (Executive Leaders)

You may find this goal generator helpful in supporting you to structure your goal effectively.

To...	Skills/ knowledge/ understand/ ability...	So that...	I will achieve this by/through...
Improve...	My understanding of...	the team I lead/ our Trust/ our students...	[List the actions you will undertake in order to achieve this goal, e.g. attending professional learning on _____, shadowing, observing, collaborating with etc]
Enhance...	My practice in relation to...		
Develop my expertise in...			
Research a series of strategies to...	Build my knowledge of...		
Practise...	My skills of...		
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"To develop my expertise in the perennial issues of teacher recruitment and retention so that we can develop and implement a Trust-wide recruitment, retention, and leadership development strategy, prioritising schools with high levels of deprivation."

"To research the barriers to social mobility in Sandwell and Walsall so that I can build an effective framework for developing leaders in our Trust to actively contribute to social mobility and system leadership"

Non-Examples

The following table gives examples of poor professional goals and the reasons they would not be suitable.

Non-example	Justification
To develop a strategy for staff wellbeing across our Trust to support retention	Whilst in the current climate, a focus on staff wellbeing is imperative, this goal is too wide to be actionable, and prioritises an action/ output over genuine personal professional learning. As an initiative, it is key that the executive leader leading this work develops expertise and knowledge in both wellbeing and in effective, context-led implementation.
Ensure that student numbers increase, particularly at Key Stage 5.	Simply stating the need to increase student numbers does not provide clarity on how this will be achieved or aligned with the Trust's values, such as being an employer of choice or focusing on social mobility. Likewise, it is not clear what the leader plans to learn to lead to the outcome described. There is no mention of specific strategies like improving retention in post-16 education or enhancing the curriculum to attract more students. Without a clear, strategic approach, this goal is unlikely to lead to sustained growth.
Work collaboratively with Trust Directors to make the Trust an employer of choice.	While the sentiment behind this goal is aligned to our mission as a Trust, it is far too broad and abstract to be actionable. There is no clear definition of what being an "employer of choice" means or how this would be measured. It also doesn't tie into specific actions like improving pay and conditions, offering professional development, or promoting internal career progression, which are concrete elements in the Trust's priorities. It is not clear what sort of learning the executive leader will undertake in order to achieve this goal, and is focused primarily on outcome, rather than the learning process.